Week 2

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 1 · LESSON 2

Faith

BIG IDEA

Biblical faith is not wandering in the darkness hoping you are right. John says the miraculous signs were written so we may believe: faith is trust based on evidence, and like any relationship, the more reasons we have to trust Christ, the deeper the relationship goes.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The speaker once saw faith as stumbling in the dark, like breaking his toe in a pitch-black apartment, and many students still see it that way.
2. John 20:30-31 says the recorded signs were written so you may believe; John gives seven escalating signs, plus the resurrection, as reasons to believe.
3. Biblical faith is trust based on evidence, and just as trust deepens human relationships, knowing Christ better deepens our relationship with him.
4. Hebrews 11:1's 'certain' carries the idea of a foundation or substructure, like a basement so solid you never fear the house will cave in.
5. Jesus kept his wounds after the resurrection, showing them to Thomas as one more reason to believe he did exactly what he said.
6. Create space for students to consider the evidence themselves, so faith becomes their own rather than borrowed from parents or leaders; that faith sticks through college.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO John 20:30-31 | Hebrews 11:1

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Do you have your own faith, or are you still believing what your parents or others told you to believe?
2. Have you considered the evidence God has given for who Jesus is? Is it enough?
3. How does trust between friends grow, and how is that like trusting Christ?
4. How can we help students move from accepting what we tell them to discovering it is true?

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WEEK 2 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Wandering in the dark

0:05 Several years ago, I was in a brand new apartment. I woke up in the middle of the night to do something — I don't remember what it was. As I went back to bed, I rammed my toe so hard into the bed frame that I ended up breaking my toe. I didn't know I had broken it until I woke up the next morning. It was black and blue, my whole foot was all messed up, and I limped around for days. The doctor told me there was nothing that could be done about it, because I had simply broken my toe. The bed wasn't new, but the apartment was. When I woke up, it was pitch black and I couldn't see a thing. Naturally, I was so disoriented — I didn't know where I was, I didn't know what was going on — that I forgot where the bed was, because I forgot where I was.

0:52 Growing up, in my younger days as an early baby Christian, that's about how I thought of faith. I thought of faith as wandering in the darkness, trying to figure something out, hoping I don't stub my toe and hoping I don't do something dumb. And in reality, in my life, I actually did stub my toe, to the point where I walked away for quite some time. As I came back to the church, I realized something: faith is not at all like wandering in the darkness. What I've discovered is that so many students still hold that belief — that faith is either attaching themselves to what their parents believe and simply going along with something, or literally wandering around in the darkness, hoping that what they believe is somehow true, and that somehow at the end of all things, when this life ends, they'll find out that it actually is true.

What John says about faith

1:49 What's interesting, though, is that John says something at the very end of his gospel that starts to speak to us about what faith actually is. It's in John chapter 20, verses 30 and 31, and John says this: "Jesus did many other miracles, or miraculous signs, in the presence of his disciples, which are not recorded in this book, but these are written that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

2:22 What's interesting is what John says here: that these miraculous signs, all of these things John has recorded in his gospel, are there so that you might believe — we are given reasons. And what's fascinating about the gospel of John is the seven miraculous signs that John gives, starting with Jesus turning water into wine and then ending with that magnitude of a miracle, the raising of Lazarus. And then, if you want to include the eighth one, Jesus' own resurrection — time after time, John sets it up so that we see, increasing in measure, all these signs that Jesus is exactly who he says he is. This is what we want students to actually get: that biblical faith is trust based on evidence, and that translates into a deeper relationship.

Trust grows a relationship

3:20 Think about the relationships that you have. You don't just blindly trust somebody you don't know, but the more you get to know somebody, the more you trust them. The more you trust them, the deeper that relationship starts to go. That's how relationships work, and it's no different with our relationship with Christ. The more we know who he is, the more we know about what's going on and what the gospel is, the more we can trust — and the more reason we have to trust in what God is doing through Christ. And the more that we do that, the deeper our relationship with him goes.

3:55 This is exactly why we start this lesson with the idea of your students' trust between friends. We want them to get that sense of what it looks like, because our best and deepest relationships are built on a sense of trust — a deep sense of trust. And we have that because that person has either continually provided reasons to trust them, or maybe not reasons to trust them. So we want our students to be able to see how that works.

Hebrews 11 and certainty

4:27 What's even more fascinating, I think, is that when we start thinking about what faith is and how this works, we naturally find ourselves in Hebrews 11. Hebrews 11:1: "Now faith is being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we do not see. This is what the ancients were commended for." Then the writer of Hebrews goes through that huge wall of faith, all these people who had the right kind of faith. We use this verse as the foundational piece of what faith means: being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we do not see. Well, that word "certain" — the word actually means, or has with it, the idea of a foundation or a substructure.

5:12 So think of it this way: it's a basement. The idea the writer is talking about is the basement in your home. When you walk downstairs into your basement — if you have one, or if you've ever walked into a basement — you generally don't fear that the whole house is going to cave in on you. Because when you've walked down into a basement, it has these huge metal beams and these metal poles, and they're driven into the cement, into the ground, and the whole house is being held up by those beams and that basement. And when you walk downstairs, you don't think anything of it. Why? Because the house is built on a solid foundation. If the foundation in the house is cracked, the house is starting to be no good, and you can't really do anything in the house until you fix the foundation.

6:00 So that's what the writer is saying. It's so sure, so fundamental, that you can walk into a house and feel totally confident — so much so that you don't even think about it. That's what faith is. It's that foundational piece of what we do not see; it's assurance of it. And in fact, if you take it one step deeper, the root word comes from the idea of an idea, or of one who stands immovable. It cannot be moved at all. One who is so rock solid and so dug into a foundation that it can't be moved. That is what our faith is, and that's what we want students to be able to see.

Why Jesus kept his wounds

6:42 Think about it for a second. I was just thinking about this the other day: why did Jesus keep his wounds? Why would Jesus — he's Jesus. He resurrects, and yet at the end of John's gospel, he shows Thomas his wounds. Thomas wants to see them. He wants to see for himself what it is that Jesus... Why? It's Jesus. He's resurrected. What more evidence do you need?

7:09 But Jesus keeps his wounds. I've always found that really fascinating — that out of all the things Jesus could have done, we'd be thinking, "Well, I'm going to fix these wounds, because why would I want to have these holes in my wrist and this gash in my side? Why would I want to keep those?" One more reason, even if it was just for Thomas. One more reason to show that this is who I am, and I've done exactly what I said I was going to do.

Small group time

7:42 So, faith. We want our students to really understand the deep roots of faith — that it's not wandering in the darkness, but that it's assurance and evidence of belief. So our small group time should be something where students can take a step back, think about it, and discuss with each other what it really means to have faith.

8:04 And I want your students to start — and you should encourage your students to start — thinking about, "Well, do I have my own faith, or am I still just believing what my parents believed, or what other people have told me to believe? Or am I starting now to believe things on my own, based on what I'm now discovering?" And that starts with asking your students: have they considered the evidence? Have they considered all of the tools that are in here, especially that God has given us, to figure out whether what Jesus did and what God is doing and the whole of salvation history is enough?

8:46 So what we're talking about is finding a space where students can start to make their faith their own. It's easy for us as leaders to stand up in front of a bunch of students and tell them about our faith, and read through Scripture, and give them an interpretation of what our faith looks like and what faith they ought to have based on our faith. But it's a whole different thing — and this is the thing we want you to start doing — to encourage students so that this transfer begins to happen: the transfer from what we're telling them to believe to what they believe based on the evidence they're discovering on their own.

9:26 We want you to create a space where students can invest, where they can pursue on their own, where they can go back to the idea of questions — where they can ask the right questions, or ask any questions for that matter — so that the evidence that's here in Scripture will come right off the page and into their lives. That's the kind of faith that sticks. That's the kind of faith they'll take with them to college. That's the kind of faith we want them to have. We don't want them to just accept what we're telling them; we want them to discover that what we're telling them is actually true.

9:59 So, three things to keep in mind. One: drive home the fact that biblical faith is not without evidence. Biblical faith is not without evidence. Number two: Jesus has taken significant time

and energy to give us that evidence. And finally, number three: for students, considering the evidence opens the door to a much deeper and more meaningful relationship with the Creator of the world.